



ENGLAND'S ENEMY

Philip II of Spain ruled over a vast empire, with lands across Europe and in the Americas. He wanted to add England to his empire and bring the country back into the Catholic faith.

England at war

FROM 1585 TO 1604, Protestant England was at war with Catholic Spain, ruled by King Philip II. The war created a mood of patriotism in the country, and people wanted to see plays drawn from English history with battles on the stage. So, in the 1590s, Shakespeare wrote nine plays dealing with English history, featuring kings, wars, and battles for the throne. A central theme of the plays is the need for order. At the time, people were worried about the war with Spain, the fact that their queen had no heir, the rumors of Catholic plots to dethrone her, and the risk of civil war.



GOD'S WINDS

For England, a dangerous moment of the war with Spain came in 1588, when Phillip sent a huge war fleet called the Armada to invade. This ended in disaster for Spain. The Armada was beaten in battle and scattered by storms. English people took this as a sign that God was on their side.

Henry comes to parliament to make his claim to the throne

Spanish galleons were taller than English ships, and harder to maneuver

FAMOUS LAST WORDS

Shakespeare's play *Richard II* tells the story of the overthrow of King Richard II by his cousin Henry Bolingbroke, who became Henry IV. The play contains Shakespeare's most famous patriotic speech, spoken by the dying John of Gaunt: "This happy breed of men, this little world, this precious stone set in a silver sea ... this blessed plot, this earth, this realm, this England."

FAT FALSTAFF

Sir John Falstaff is the drunken old knight who befriends young Prince Hal in Shakespeare's two *Henry IV* plays. The plays show a series of rebellions against Henry IV, whose troubled reign is God's punishment for overthrowing Richard II. Prince Hal grows into a heroic figure who will make a great king, but first he must reject Falstaff.



FOR KING AND COUNTRY

Prince Hal reappears as the king in *Henry V*, the story of England's great victory over the French at the Battle of Agincourt in 1415. "Follow your spirit," cries the king, rallying his men, "and upon this charge, cry God for Harry, England, and Saint George!"

